which indicate the areas requiring further calibration and honing of processes to deliver the intended outcomes; and the involvement of the community or target groups for whom the schemes are meant.

The exercise is a joint effort of the Finance Ministry and the Planning Commission. The latter gave final shape to the consolidated Outcome Budget of the administrative ministries after detailed discussion with them. The document will also be put up on the web for the people to give their comments.

A new division called the Programme Outcome and Response Monitoring Division has been created within the Planning Commission to co-ordinate the initiative. The Division will try to bring a fair Degree of uniformity of approach across the Ministries, but with due regard to the special nature of their collective responsibilities, programmes, and projects. This means that while it is relatively easy to find out if the defence ministry has spent its budget to buy a new weapons system, it is far more difficult to establish if Rs. 100 crore spent on a block has helped families to move above the poverty line. So the yardsticks have to take into account such differences.

Some of the common yardsticks to be employed to measure outcome include standardising the unit cost of delivery, bench-marking the standards and quality of outcome, and capacity-building of requisite efficiency at all levels, in terms of equipment, technology, knowledge and skills. Accordingly, implementing agencies will have a clearer idea of what is expected of them, and can be assessed against agreed performance indicators.

OVER THE COUNTER

The financial papers/securities which can be bought or sold through a private dealer or bank rather than on a financial exchange. The term has its use in the non-financial world too–purchasing medicines from a medical store without the doctor’s prescription is an over-the-counter deal in drugs.

PARALLEL IMPORTING